GameXP.KARMZAH
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INTRO

My initial impressions, feedback and reference points for what is “good” are all filtered through my particular biases some of which include:

- Being 2nd generation Jamaican American, born and raised around New York City suburbs.
- Playing mostly Japanese console games as a child and more US/EU PC games as an adolescent.
- Working abroad in Japan as an educator and in entry level QA/Production/Design/Community positions at a few different game companies.
- Studying Games for Learning at NYU under the tutelage of Eric Zimmerman & Jan Plass.

Games can be portals into other worlds for our minds and the perceived depth of that journey depends heavily on the intersection of the player’s psychology AND the combination of elements that designers bring to an experience. There is a lot that can be said here about psychology, culture, conditioning, expectations, escapism and how those psychological processes affect what is perceived as “good.” I think designers would do well to consider how an audience and their relative psychologies intersect with a given game design intent. However, this feedback is focused on the game design part of the equation.

Without thoroughly addressing psychology for the time being, I think the multi-disciplinary nature of games means there are many avenues to connect with people. Art direction, music composition, gameplay mechanics, level design, narrative, exploration & progression, systems/interaction design, etc. are each another opportunity to connect with a player and add another layer of depth to an experience.

Regarding Karmzah, my first impressions were that there is still a lot of friction in each of the aforementioned areas that prevent a stronger connection with players. I know this is still a demo with more work to be done and not a finished product, but in the context of discussions with Eyram around why African made games have not yet found ‘great success’ (loaded term) internationally, I will try to give more commercially oriented feedback as I would like for it to find said success. And as I step through my feedback, I would like designers to keep a question in mind: What do we want the player to feel from this experience?

For Karmzah, my reference points are games like Super Metroid, Streets of Rage 4, Absolum, Castlevania series, Ori series, Dead Cells, Hollow Knight, to name a few. For me, these are the some of the ‘best’ action adventure side-scrollers, each operating in similar spaces with similar design vocabulary and gameplay mechanics. Each of those execute well in areas of combat, controls, art, narrative, music, exploration, progression and especially vibes. By vibes I mean even if all elements aren’t perfect in any one game, the elements come together in that game experience to make the player feel something of significance; to feel heroic, to feel isolated, to feel clever, to feel tension, to feel triumph, to feel empowered, to feel discovery. If making a game in this space, I think there is value in aiming for what those games do well and aiming for what those games make the player feel.

As an African American, I feel that there may also be somewhat of an international bias against African cultures that may or may not be worth acknowledging when considering why African games haven’t reached higher international success as of yet. Though that may contribute, that is a more complex discussion than I’ll address here and there are enough practical things to focus on in the meantime.

FEEDBACK

I do quite like some of the narrative background with the main character and the idea of her turning her crutches / “disability” into a superpower and a god supporting her self-transformation. I also like the character art and the comic style story scenes. However, some more narrative setup/world building to introduce characters, gods, context, etc. would be appreciated.

The games cited above are high bars, but if we can’t execute on everything, I think the top 3 essentials are controls, combat/exploration and art/aesthetics. Controls need to feel tight and responsive. I want immediate feedback on most, if not all of my actions, but in Karmzah there is a significant delay between my button press and attacks/jumps/etc. triggering on screen. I don’t know how the game is coded, but the input delay is currently a bit too high in my humble opinion so reducing this by speeding up attack animations or reducing input delay, etc. could improve this feeling and build a stronger connection between players and their on screen avatar.

Every game doesn’t need combat and can be well served with puzzles or exploration. However, since combat seems to be a large focus on Karmzah, I next want to highlight how the combat feels a little mushy. By mushy, I mean that the game isn’t communicating enough information about the result of my attack. I want more feedback when my attack hits/misses an enemy. Windup SFX, impact SFX on contact, reeling animation on contact, health bar depletion on contact (which implies room to improve the UI- enemy health bars are currently too thin), screen shake, VFX on hit, combo/special attack meter increase on contact, etc. Some of that is there in the current build, but the combat experience is missing pieces and not currently coming together to make me feel like my attacks have weight to them. If there is a limit on what can be added to the combat, then perhaps more interesting puzzles (requiring specific combinations of abilities to clear), more exploration (using different combinations of abilities to access different parts of the map), more progression (gating ability unlocks behind map exploration), and/or some roguelike elements to add variety to enemy encounters or level design (though I personally don’t care for the ongoing ‘rougelike-ification’ of the industry, I recognize the popularity), could all help build a more engaging connection with the game for the players.

Lastly, the art generally feels flat to me. Not bad, but not outstanding. There is a lot of unique art out there across the vast Africa diaspora. However, the art in this demo does not feel particularly unique or different. The character art is cool, but I’m talking more about environment design, visual design theme, UI elements and how those integrate with the level design, etc. The narrative background of falling into an ancient tomb provides a lot of opportunity for more expressive art direction. If each tomb represents some lost or hidden culture, each tomb or even each section within one tomb can be an opportunity to put a unique art style on display with different colors, symbols, patterns, architecture, characters, etc.

There is a lot more room to improve on things like, music, narrative, exploration, puzzle design, etc. but I will digress for now, and we can return to other elements later if there is space, time & interest.

Overall, I think Karmzah has a decent foundation with **a lot** of untapped potential. This theme and cultural specificity is sorely under-represented & explored across the industry so I want to see it do well. There is a lot I don’t know about your budgets, resources, schedules, stakeholders, etc. And I am making many assumptions based on my biases and gaming influences, but as a fan of the games mentioned, and as a fan rooting for LetiArts’ success, these are some of the things I noticed might help Karmzah connect more deeply with players and hopefully also ‘successfully’ reach a broader global audience.

TL;DR

1. NARRATIVE
    a. Comic book style narrative storytelling is cool, but creates some distance between the game art and the story scenes. How to make them more similar?
    b. Not much context. Is this story for people who already know the lore, the history and background?
    c. If Karmzah is for a wider audience, there could be some intro context to introduce the cosmology/philosophy/context of Muzu, Morowa, and the archeological site, the artifacts, etc.
2. CONTROLS
    a. Jump is too floaty.
    b. Movement is not snappy. There is still too much delay between button presses and actions taking effect on screen.
    c. Double jump is inconsistent
        i. First jump is too low
        ii. Second jump window closes too early. Should be able to activate 2nd jump later in animation.
        iii. 2nd jump is really high, make more sense to just do long press normal jump in most cases
3. MUSIC / SFX
    a. Ambient track from trailer is good, but more good music to match atmosphere.
    b. SFX aren't tightly synced to each action, some SFX are not mixed loud enough
4. COMBAT
    a. Good
        i. Solid foundation for action game, with light/heavy/charge attacks, combos, parry, dodge, etc
    b. Poor
        i. More hit stun/stop
        ii. Enemies can be more aggressive
        iii. Parry should have more delay, more of a penalty for mis-timing?
        iv. There should be a stagger/stun meter so players can track their stun progress on an enemy
        v. Charge attack animation takes too long to complete and to release
        vi. Should be higher penalty for taking damage
        vii. Window for chaining attacks to do combos is not clear
            1. Audio and/or visual cue might help
5. ART
    a. Cool character design,
        i. Why are her clothe glowing in the first section
        ii. Is voice acting planned?
    b. Art does not feel unique.
    c. The ancient tomb is an opportunity to create a unique design vocabulary with symbols, patterns, colors, architecture, but it feels generic. Not bad, just not unique.
        i. There are opportunities to tie UI elements into different elements of the tomb. Health meter, combo counter, enemy name text, etc. can share some visual element design
6. UI/UX
    a. Text needs a little more padding in text boxes, there is some overlap covering dialogue text
7. EXPLORATION / PROGRESSION
    a. More interesting puzzles
        i. Require different combinations of movement/traversal/combat abilities
    b. Can place abilities in treasure chests
        i. Maybe chests can be changed for ancient knowledge /artifacts that teach the player new skills/abilities

CRASHLOGS: Crash during 1st elite fight, Crash in front of two treasure chests. *see crash log .ZIP files attached*